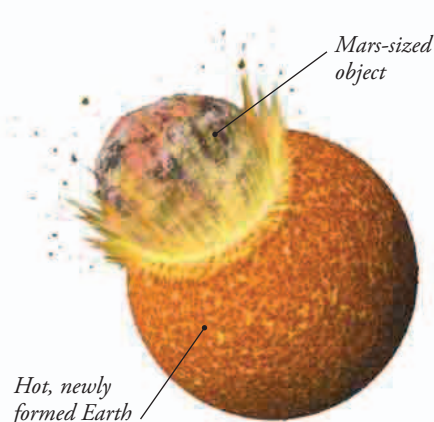


FORMATION OF THE MOON

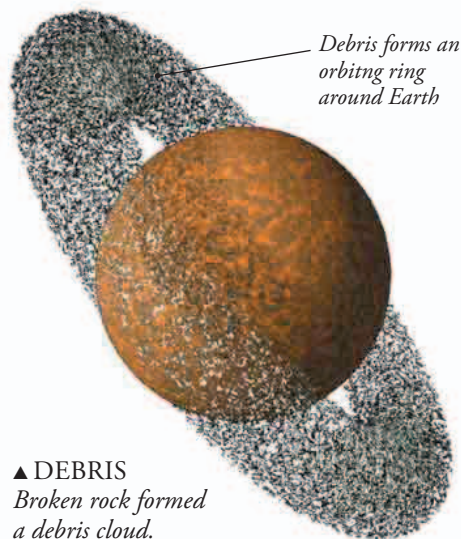
The Moon was probably created by the biggest crash in Earth's history, when our newly formed planet collided with a smaller planet, roughly the size of Mars. Molten material from the impact formed the Moon. The smaller planet seems to have been completely destroyed,

because analysis of Moon rock shows that it is made of the same material as Earth's deep rocky mantle. Earth would have been partly melted again by the impact, but it would then have solidified in layers, as before.



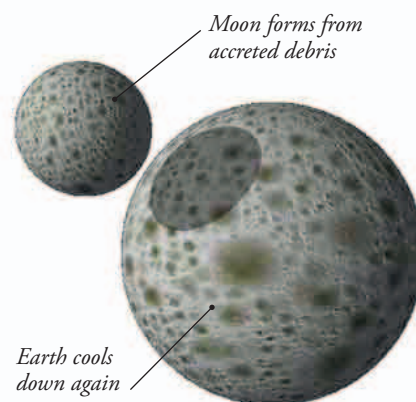
▲ COLLISION

Around 4.5 billion years ago, Earth was hit by another planet.



▲ DEBRIS

Broken rock formed a debris cloud.

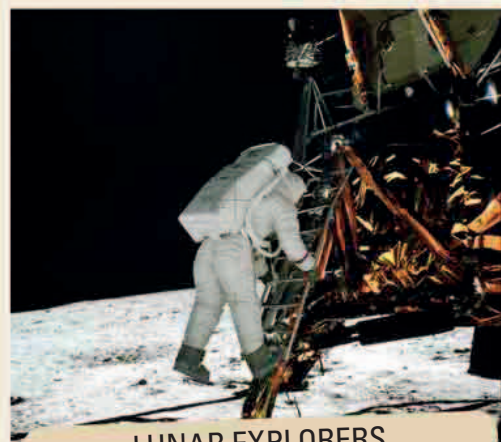
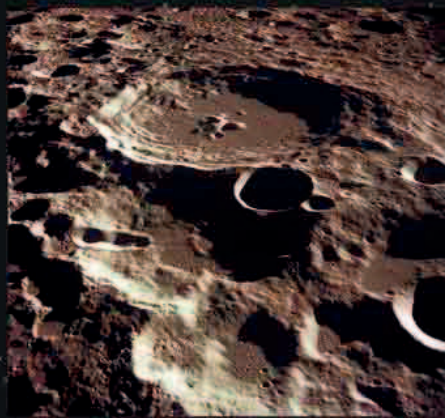


▲ SOLID PARTNERS

The debris clumped together and then melted to form the Moon.

IMPACT CRATERS

The Moon's surface is marked by craters, caused by big meteorite impacts in the distant past. Some of the biggest craters have been flooded with volcanic rock to form dark maria (seas). Many smaller, younger craters also cover the surface of the Moon.



LUNAR EXPLORERS

In July 1969, America's Apollo space program sent the first human explorers to set foot on the Moon. This image shows the second man on the Moon, Buzz Aldrin, photographed by the first, Neil Armstrong. Just 12 people have explored the Moon as part of six Apollo missions, the last of which was in 1972. The final three missions explored the surface using a Lunar Roving Vehicle, seen in the main image (left).

